eighty stadia [*c*. 14 km] in length and fifteen [*c*. 2.5 km] in breadth. It is of the shape of a parallellogram and is girded by a wooden wall, pierced with loopholes for the discharge of arrows. It has a ditch in front for defence and for receiving the sewage of the city.'[18] The description makes the city long and narrow.[19] One calculation suggests this would mean a city that covered some 4500 hectares.[20] What archaeology has revealed of its size does not exactly compare with the calculations above, but the spread of its ancient ruins does make it clear that the city was a very large one.

It is not easy to get archaeological precision on the size of the urban metropolis as it stood during Mauryan times since the houses and palaces, the streets and markets, the pillars and sculptures, and so much else of Pataliputra lies buried under some twenty-two centuries of strata below modern Patna. So, how have archaeologists managed to arrive at a rough calculation of its size? This has been possible because wooden ramparts of the sort described by Megasthenes have been detected in various areas of the city. They have not been unearthed in a continuous line, but even so, by plotting on a map wherever these were found, a conjectural sense of size can be obtained.[21] One calculation is that the area enclosed by the timber ramparts would have been around 2200 hectares; another assessment computes the fortified city as much smaller, between 1200 and 1300 hectares. Either way, as the archaeologist F.R. Allchin put it, 'even if the more modest figures are anywhere near correct, Pataliputra would have been far larger than any other South Asian city of its day, and on this score alone would certainly qualify for the title of Metropolis.'[22] Ashoka would later travel to other cities in the course of his duties as a prince, and when doing so is likely to have noticed that many of these too had massive ramparts and overlooked rivers. But they will have seemed Lilliputian compared to his ancestral city. Two locations that figure prominently in Ashoka's early years are Vidisha and Taxila. The ramparts of Vidisha enclosed around 240 hectares, while the Mauryan city at Taxila covered a